Zagzebski on Truth and the Third Condition

Why adding more conditions to true belief will never keep Gettier cases out.

The tripartite view and reliabilism share one approach. Both say that knowledge is **true belief + a third condition** – justification, or being the product of a reliable cognitive process. This third condition is closely connected to truth but **independent** from it.

Gettier cases show the cost of that independence: the third condition can come apart from truth. The belief is true by **luck**, not as a result of the third condition.

> **Key Thesis**
> Zagzebski argues that as long as the third condition is independent of truth, it does not matter how we add to the conditions for knowledge. We will **always** be able to construct a Gettier case that shows the proposed definition is incorrect.

Part 01 The recipe for a Gettier case

Call the additional conditions **Q** (justification, justification + no false lemmas, reliable cognitive processes, and so on). The proposed definition is: knowledge = true belief that is Q.

1. **Bad luck.** Start with a belief that is Q but false. *Henry believes, of a façade in Barn County, that it is a barn.*
2. **Good luck.** Now add some good luck so the belief is true after all. *Henry happens to be looking at the one real barn in Barn County.*
3. **Still Q, but not knowledge.** The true belief is Q, because it is exactly like the false belief that is Q. It just happens, by luck, to be true – so it is not knowledge.
4. **Conclusion.** For any theory where Q is independent of truth, knowledge is not true belief + Q.

Part 02 Why not just say ‘not accidentally true’?

Suppose we define knowledge as true belief that is not accidentally true. Two points follow.

1. **It is a terrible definition.** It is vague, negative and no help. What is a ‘non-accidentally true’ belief?
2. **It is no objection to Zagzebski.** This third condition is not independent of truth, so her argument still stands.

Key idea We need a definition that shows **how and why** truth and the third condition are connected, not merely added together. As with justification and reliability, this connection will have something to do with why knowledge is good in a way that mere true belief is not.

Consolidation question

Explain how Zagzebski's 'recipe' shows that knowledge cannot be defined as true belief + a third condition (Q) that is independent of truth. Use Henry in Barn County to illustrate each step.

Check you have covered: what Q is · the bad luck step · the good luck step · why the belief is Q but not knowledge · her conclusion.